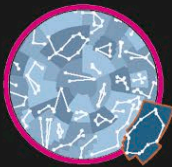


THE SAILS

Vela



SIZE RANKING 32

BRIGHTEST STAR
Gamma (γ) 1.8

GENITIVE Velorum

ABBREVIATION Vel

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM
February–April

FULLY VISIBLE
32°N–90°S

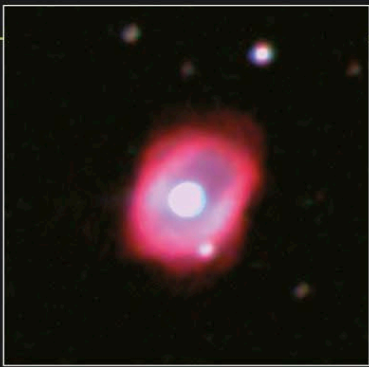


In the 18th century, the ancient Greek constellation Argo Navis (the ship of Jason and the Argonauts—see panel, below) was divided into three parts, one of which was Vela, which represents the ship's sails. Because the stars labeled Alpha (α) and Beta (β) in the former Argo Navis are now in Carina, to the south, the labeling of the stars in Vela starts with Gamma (γ) Velorum, or Regor (see p.253).

Between Gamma and Lambda (λ) Velorum are found the gaseous strands of the Vela supernova remnant (see p.269)—the supernova could have been seen from Earth around 11,000 years ago—while Delta (δ) and Kappa (κ) Velorum combine with two stars in Carina to form the False Cross (sometimes mistaken for the true Southern Cross).

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Gamma Velorum is the brightest example of a Wolf–Rayet star, a rare type of star that has lost its outer layers, thereby exposing its ultra-hot interior. A 4th-magnitude companion is visible through a small telescope or good binoculars. In addition, two



THE EIGHT-BURST NEBULA 天鵝座

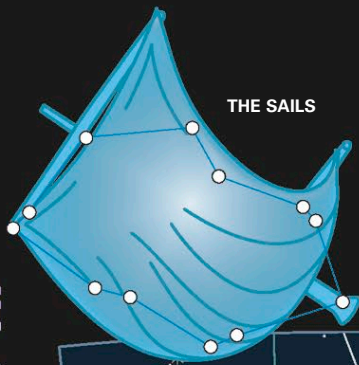
The planetary nebula NGC 3132 has loops of gas that interlock like figure-eights, hence the object's popular name.

wider companions, with components of 8th and 9th magnitudes, are visible through a telescope.

IC 2391 is the best star cluster in Vela for the naked eye or binoculars. It is a group of several dozen stars covering a greater area than a full moon. To the north of it is another binocular cluster, IC 2395.

NGC 2547 is an open cluster half the size of a full moon and can be identified through binoculars or a small telescope.

Popularly known as the Eight-Burst Nebula, NGC 3132 has complex loops that are revealed only through a large telescope or on long-exposure photographs. A small telescope will show the nebula's disk, of similar apparent size to Jupiter, and the 10th-magnitude star at its center.



THE SAILS

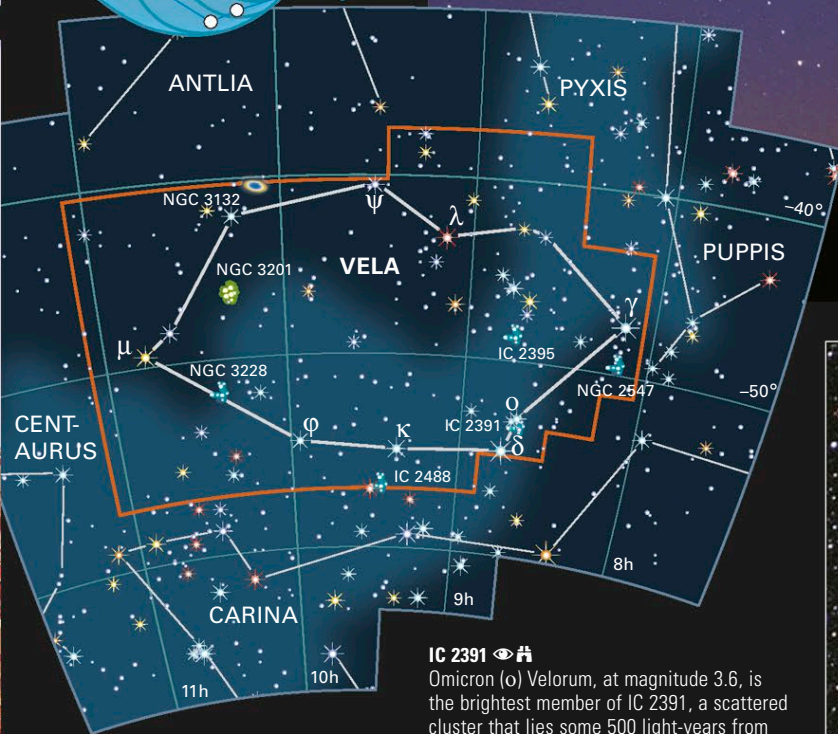
MYTHS AND STORIES

THE ARGONAUTS

The *Argo* was a mighty 50-oared galley in which Jason and 50 of the greatest Greek heroes, called the Argonauts, sailed to Colchis, on the eastern shore of the Black Sea, on their mission to find the golden fleece of a ram. Their epic voyage is one of the great stories of Greek myth.

LEGENDARY SAILING GALLEY

The *Argo*, ship of the Argonauts, is here depicted by the Italian artist Lorenzo Costa (1459–1535).



IC 2391 天鵝座

Omicron (ο) Velorum, at magnitude 3.6, is the brightest member of IC 2391, a scattered cluster that lies some 500 light-years from Earth in the southern reaches of Vela.

UNDER SAIL 天鵝座

Vela represents the mainsail of the *Argo*, the ship of Jason and the Argonauts, sailing through the southern sky in the quest for the golden fleece.

